

Farming

Since prehistoric times, people have been turning forests, wild grasslands, and even some deserts into farmland. For most of that time, the cropland has been fertilized by grazing livestock. As the world's population has grown, however, farmers have needed to produce more food by developing more intensive, mechanized methods that rely on chemical fertilizers and pesticides.



SLASH AND BURN

The most primitive way of growing food is to clear an area of forest, burn the tree stumps, and plant crops on the soil fertilized by the ash. People in the Amazon rainforest have always farmed like this, but it only works on a small scale. The soil soon loses its nutrients and then more forest has to be cleared.

HERDING AND RANCHING

The first farmers were probably animal herders. Instead of hunting animals, they caught them and kept them for their milk, meat, and skins. The earliest herders may have followed animals as they roamed. Ranchers still herd animals today, driving them from pasture to pasture on open ranges for grazing.

▼ OPEN RANGE

This rancher herds cattle across a vast open range in Idaho.

